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Don't Blame Hindu Assertion

It's easy to link communal flare-ups with the BJP's so-called strategy of polarising voters, but that would lead to flawed conclusions and, consequently, wrong solutions



Illustration by NILANJAN DAS

There are two important aspects of the recent series of violent happenings obliquely referred to as 'communal incidents': their frequency and the increasing number of locations. The incidents cannot be dismissed as mere statistics nor can one wish to bring them under control with mere statements. There seems to be a deeper malaise at work, an attempt to create a different and dangerous narrative. Politicising these riots and blaming one or the other political party will not only be deceptive but also socially perilous, and subvert the democratic process that guarantees religious freedom and human rights.

With the BJP being the ruling party, it is easy to link these incidents to its so-called strategy of polarising voters on communal lines. Ironically, even as the flare-ups were making headlines, the party lost all the five bypolls held across four states. So much for the political advantage to the BJP!

Communal riots have always been analysed with different yardsticks. When processions by Hindus are attacked, the general refrain is to advise them to avoid Muslim localities and stop playing music when passing by a mosque. But the objection from Hindu organisations, and certainly a valid one, is that no one usually advises the intolerant sections among Muslims to respect the religious feelings of Hindus and other communities. Those who argue that stone-pelting in Jahangirpuri, Delhi, was a result